
STUDY COMPANION

THINKING INSIDE THE CREASE

The Mental Secrets to Becoming a Dominant Lacrosse Goalie

Christian K. Buck

A companion guide · Read · Reference · Listen

THE FRAMEWORK

Why the mental game decides everything in the cage

Christian Buck learned the lesson the hard way. In college he fought for six months to win back his starting job — and won it — only to lose it for good when, as he puts it, he got “so busy trying to keep my job, I didn’t do my job.” A goalie’s job is not to perform, impress, or protect a starting spot. It is to stop the ball. Period.

Everything in this companion sits on a single equation, borrowed from sport psychologist Dr. Rick Jensen and woven through every chapter:

$$\text{Performance} = \text{Talent} - \text{Interference} +/\text{Luck}$$

Talent is the physical, trainable side — angles, hand speed, stick skills. Luck is the bounce you can’t control. The book lives in the middle term: **Interference**, the mental noise that hides your talent. Fear, anxiety, the downward spiral, a wandering focus — these are the things you learn to drive toward zero, so the talent you’ve earned can finally show through.

THE ARC OF THIS COMPANION

I. Squaring Up lays the foundation — how performance works, how to beat fear, how to stay in the present, where to look, and how to play with a “Bring It!” mind.

II. The Dominant Mind builds durable strength — mental toughness, the lacrosse hierarchy, taking responsibility, managing anxiety, breaking the spiral, the warm-up, and generating confidence.

III. Under the Lights turns to the science and the stage — reaction time, optical optimization, earning the field, dominating showcases, and putting it all together on game day.

Part II then reorganizes every idea into a three-phase action plan — **Train, Compete, Dominate** — followed by a one-page Quick Reference you can pin to your mirror.

MOVEMENT I

SQUARING UP

The inner-game foundation

01

Talent – Interference +/- Luck

How performance actually works

“As preparation increases, so does confidence. And as confidence increases, anxiety decreases.”

KEY MOMENTS

- Dr. Rick Jensen’s performance formula breaks every game into three parts — **Talent** (your physical, strategic, and technical skill), **Interference** (anything mental that detracts from it), and **Luck** (the bounces you can’t control).
- Talent is trainable and moves only incrementally; its most important piece is your **angles** — how square your stick, shoulders, hips, and feet are to the shooter.
- Interference can swing wildly. It comes from outside (weather, fans, a new pocket) and inside (fatigue, anxiety, fear). The goal is to keep your interference score near zero so your talent shows through.
- Luck follows the law of averages over a season — a stick deflection here, a bad rebound there. Accept it and move on; re-litigating a bad bounce only adds interference.

THE CORE LESSON

Performance equals the talent you’ve trained minus the mental interference you allow, plus or minus the luck you can’t control. Build talent daily and drive interference toward zero.

TAKEAWAYS

First. Build talent every day through hard, deliberate work — it only improves in small increments.

Second. Identify the interference sources that most affect you and build coping strategies in practice, not in the State Championship.

Third. The fastest way to cut interference is to lock onto the release and contact point with an aggressive mind.

Fourth. Recognize luck for what it is, accept it, and refuse to dwell on a bad bounce.

02

Fear

The single most debilitating factor

“Your desire to stop the ball must be greater than the fear of getting hit or letting up a goal.”

KEY MOMENTS

- Buck names it plainly: the physiological effects of fear are the single most debilitating factor of playing goalie. The most common source is simply the fear of pain — that shot that stings for days.
- Fear is the anticipation of harm in the **present**; anxiety is the anticipation of harm in the **future**. Fear fires the amygdala, floods the body with adrenaline, tightens the muscles, and makes you “shrink” —

dropping to your knees, closing your eyes, tucking elbows.

- At a Phoenix clinic, Buck took two hard shots passively to the same spot. On the third he decided that if he was getting hit, it would be on **his** terms — he attacked the shot, took it in the shoulder, and called the bruise a badge of honor.
- Before a State Championship he asked a goalie how many bruises she could go earn. She made sixteen saves and won the title.

THE CORE LESSON

Fear comes down to fight or flight. Choose to fight: build an aggressive mindset before the ball is in the air, and reframe getting hit as earning your bruises.

TAKEAWAYS

First. Watch film of the goals you let in, not just your saves, to find your fear tendencies.

Second. Counteract the protective brain on purpose — loose hands, dropped shoulders, an exaggerated step forward, eyes wide.

Third. Use “Lock In, Lock Out”: focus so hard on the release point that the limbic system never fires.

Fourth. Flip into fight mode well before the shot, and chase the bruise instead of avoiding it.

03

One Shot at a Time

The next shot is the only shot

“The next shot will always, always, always be more important than the last one.”

KEY MOMENTS

- A college basketball player told Buck that starting 0-for-2 ruined his game. Buck asked if he’d be happy shooting eighty percent — the order you miss in is irrelevant.
- Tiger Woods gives himself ten seconds to be furious after a bad shot — he yells, he throws the club — but he never carries it into the next swing.
- The IMG Academies use a routine called **Release, Replan, Refocus** to reset after every goal.
- Buck’s post-goal routine: toss the ball to the ref, talk to the defense about what broke down, let yourself be upset for a few seconds facing the cage, then turn upfield ready for the next shot.

THE CORE LESSON

Condition your mind to live in the present and turn completely to the next shot. The past matters only for what it teaches you about the shot ahead.

TAKEAWAYS

First. Release the goal — ten seconds to react like Tiger, then let it go.

Second. Replan — adjust the plan: force the shooter’s off-hand, or have the defense slide earlier.

Third. Refocus — track the ball again and regain the present, just like the opening whistle.

Fourth. Stop banking on momentum or a “first save” — negative momentum works exactly the same way.

04

Release Point / Contact Point

If you can't see it, you can't stop it

“Without finding the release and contact point, you are just guessing — hoping the ball hits you.”

KEY MOMENTS

- Buck put a video camera in the goal and discovered the release point is two to three feet from the shooter's shoulder — and three to four feet from the ear on a sidearm shot — far wider than he had assumed.
- Your eyes can't track a fast ball continuously; they take snapshots and fast-forward to where it ends up — the **contact point**. College shots reach one hundred fourteen miles per hour.
- A wrestler-goalie kept retreating from shots until Buck had him tell each shooter “I own you” — the same thing he told opponents on the mat.
- The **Break the Glass** drill: imagine a ten-by-ten pane a foot in front of your stick and make contact before the ball breaks it; after every shot ask, “Did you save the glass?”

THE CORE LESSON

After angles and technique, finding the release point and contact point is the single most important thing a goalie does — and the contact point must always be in front of you.

TAKEAWAYS

First. Find the ball the instant it leaves the stick — remember the release is three to four feet from the shoulder.

Second. Keep your chin up and eyes wide so fear can't make you dip; try looking through the lower bars of your mask.

Third. Finish every save moving forward, even outside the crease, so the contact point stays ahead of you.

Fourth. Give every drill a purpose — “Break the Glass” only works if you ask the question each time.

05

“Bring It!”

Dare them to shoot

“That ball is yours. It is a mindset that is ripe for championships.”

KEY MOMENTS

- Buck's fantasy-team question: nobody ever picks the technically sound but timid goalie. Everyone takes the aggressive, confident goalie with so-so technique — because technique isn't what matters most.
- The greatest golfers — Palmer, Nicklaus, Player, Woods, Mickelson, Jones — have wildly different swings; what they share is striking the ball solidly. The same is true of elite goalies from Galloway to Rogers.
- What every great goalie has in common is the mindset: aggressive, confident, almost visible — the kind that makes the whole team better just to be near.
- You can't yell at the top of your lungs on low energy, so forcing yourself to be loud spikes your intensity and shifts your physiology to ready.

THE CORE LESSON

Choose an aggressive, confident “Bring It!” mindset that wants the other team to shoot — because your desire to stop the ball has to outweigh the fear of letting it in.

TAKEAWAYS

First. Say “Bring It! I own you!” on every shot — in warm-ups, before games, and again at halftime to refresh.

Second. Be as loud as possible to change your physiology into an aggressive, ready state.

Third. Stop chasing perfect technique; desire to stop the ball is the common thread among the greats.

Fourth. Drill the mindset flip relentlessly with a coach — it's hard, but it's not impossible.

MOVEMENT II

THE DOMINANT MIND

Building durable mental strength

Mental Toughness

A learnable psychological edge

“Mental toughness lets you remain determined, focused, confident, and in control under pressure.”

KEY MOMENTS

- Dr. Robert Harmison taught Buck that mental toughness is partly natural and partly **learned** — the ability to cope with the demands of sport better than your opponent.
- An NCAA freshman, the night before his first start against the second-ranked team in the country, was asked how he'd sleep. “Like a baby.” That is unshakable belief.
- Final Four players feel the exact symptoms of an anxiety disorder — racing heart, short breath, sweaty palms — yet nobody would trade places. Pressure is self-created, and what you create you can change.
- The toughest athlete Buck worked with won every sprint, ran winter track, captained a state-champ football team, and lived in the weight room — then went on to a top-ten Division One program.

THE CORE LESSON

Mental toughness is built, not born. Rate yourself across its components, then convert one weakness at a time into a strength — weaknesses don't disappear on their own.

TAKEAWAYS

First. Judge yourself against your own standards and your process, never against the other goalie.

Second. Control the controllables — your thoughts, actions, preparation, and reactions — and release everything else.

Third. Embrace competitive anxiety and pressure as the privilege of competing, not a threat.

Fourth. Refuse self-imposed limits, and turn one of your ten components from a weakness into a strength.

The Lacrosse Hierarchy

Climb the pyramid, level by level

“Only hard work will move you up to the next level. Nothing is out of your reach.”

KEY MOMENTS

- Buck's pyramid runs from **Work Ethic / Desire** at the base up through fundamentals, team offense and defense, game scenarios, **Composure**, mastery, and finally improvisation and creativity.
- The base level forces an honest question about motivation: **ego orientation** (status, accolades, anger at a bad day) versus **mastery orientation** (learning the task — “get curious, not mad”).

- Matt Danowski, once the NCAA all-time points leader, played wallball every day before practice and games throughout college — so what's your excuse?
- A goalie is the quarterback, assistant coach, and defensive coordinator at once — you must know your own defense and the opponent's offense; top programs clear the ball ninety-five percent of the time.

THE CORE LESSON

Move up the pyramid only through honest self-assessment and daily work, aiming for composure and beyond — and you can't reach composure until the fundamentals are automatic.

TAKEAWAYS

First. Be honest about your work ethic and desire — they decide how far your career can go.

Second. Choose mastery over ego: judge your own play and get curious about what broke down.

Third. Master fundamentals AND team offense and defense — you're the quarterback of the unit.

Fourth. Treat composure as the target level, and ask your coach honestly where you stand.

08

Taking Responsibility

Responsibility = Response Ability

"Only when you take responsibility for all shots can you make the appropriate adjustments."

KEY MOMENTS

- "Coach, it's not my fault — the defense didn't slide." Buck calls this a defense mechanism: blaming the defense to release the responsibility of doing your job.
- On a broken clear that ends in a one-on-one, the bad pass isn't your fault — but giving up before the shot because you're still upset is. Stop the ball and help your teammate.
- Owning every goal is the only thing that lets you adjust — if a goal is never your fault, you'd never have to fix anything. Your defense also respects you more for it.
- Richard Innes' phrase reframes the whole position: split "responsibility" into **response ability** — the ability to respond however you choose.

THE CORE LESSON

Take responsibility for every goal, no matter the circumstance — only ownership gives you the ability to respond and improve.

TAKEAWAYS

First. It's your job to stop the ball regardless of the situation — even three men down.

Second. Stop yelling at the defense; deflecting blame creates frustration and tightness.

Third. Owning the goal converts "responsibility" into "response ability."

Fourth. Release the shot, help your teammate, and move on — respect follows.

Anxiety

Recognize it, breathe, embrace it

“Embrace the anxiety. It’s why you play in the first place. You could be home on the couch.”

KEY MOMENTS

- Up ten to seven with three minutes left, you let one in, then another — ten to nine, the other team with the ball. That tightening is a high state of anxiety: the anticipation of future harm.
- Its symptoms are physical — racing heart, tight shoulders and hands, short shallow breaths, sweat, and the “butterflies” of a shutting-down digestive system.
- Some goalies explode at the ball in big games out of nerves, even though all week in practice they stood tall and waited — an anxious response that moves them before the ball is in the air.
- Buck’s counter-intuitive tip: put a little weight on your **heels**. It forces you to stand tall and sit on the release a beat longer.

THE CORE LESSON

You can’t change what you don’t diagnose, so recognize the physical symptoms of anxiety first — then slow down, breathe, loosen up, and welcome the nerves.

TAKEAWAYS

First. Identify your anxiety symptoms: heart rate, tight muscles, shallow breath, sweat.

Second. Slow down with long, deep breaths to drop your heart rate and loosen your muscles.

Third. Try weight on your heels to stand tall and wait on the release instead of lunging early.

Fourth. Embrace the nerves — if you didn’t care, you wouldn’t feel them.

The Downward Spiral

Never bank on momentum

“He recognized he was playing scared, made the adjustment, and climbed his way out.”

KEY MOMENTS

- Dr. Gio Valiante’s research shows fear “resupplies its own strength”: low self-efficacy releases norepinephrine, muscles tense, capillaries constrict, the grip tightens, more shots go in — and the cycle feeds on itself.
- A top-ten team came out playing not to lose; their elite goalie let in nine in the first half.
- At halftime Buck told him his hands were stuck to his chest. “THEY ARE COMPLETELY STUCK TO MY CHEST!” he shouted — he already knew.

- In the second half he repeated “Bring it” over and over: head higher, hands out front, moving better — and made roughly twelve saves.

THE CORE LESSON

The spiral runs on momentum and fear, so never wait on a “first save” — refocus on the next shot to keep it from starting, and flip back to “Bring It!” to climb out.

TAKEAWAYS

First. The spiral is built on momentum, and goalies don’t bank on momentum.

Second. Drop the “I’ll be fine after the first save” myth — it actually feeds the spiral.

Third. Always refocus on the next shot’s release so the spiral never begins.

Fourth. Climb out mid-game by flipping back to an aggressive mindset — head up, hands out.

11

The Warm-Up

Practice makes permanent

“Practice doesn’t make perfect. Practice makes permanent.”

KEY MOMENTS

- Every warm-up must have a purpose. Fifteen focused minutes a day — nearly two hours a week — is where you actually build technique, since the season leaves little time.
- Instead of the six fixed spots, Buck shoots randomly within the top, middle, and lower thirds of the cage plus bouncers — far more realistic than knowing where the ball is going.
- One goalie faced the cage between every save, turning back only when fully focused; he takes just six to ten shots a minute — and now plays for a national championship team.
- Before games, use a **trigger** — a gladiator pulling on helmet and gloves, or a set of songs — fifteen to thirty minutes out to reach your optimal zone; then in the pre-game warm-up, stop fixing technique and just play.

THE CORE LESSON

Give every warm-up a clear purpose and treat it like game day, because practice makes permanent — and use a pre-game trigger to enter your optimal mindset.

TAKEAWAYS

First. Give every warm-up a specific purpose, and work technique only after you’re warm.

Second. Warm up in random thirds of the cage, not fixed spots, to mirror a real game.

Third. Build a pre-game trigger — gladiator, music — to reach your zone fifteen to thirty minutes out.

Fourth. In the pre-game warm-up, stop adjusting technique — just play, commit, and throw outlets.

Confidence

Something you generate

“Confidence is a belief that things will turn out well because you are willing, worthy, and capable.”

KEY MOMENTS

- At the G3 camp a goalie said the pros “looked” confident. But confidence is an emotion — so Buck asked what it looks like: ready to act, aggressively relaxed, holding the stance into the shot, tracking release to contact.
- Brendon Burchard says confidence is generated, not given — like a power plant that doesn’t **have** energy but **generates** it.
- You can’t control whether you start, but you can influence your coach by mastering the controllables — technique, work ethic, angles, preparation, mindset — and by building competence.
- Confident body language — chin up, shoulders back, chest out — creates the feeling; and small, written goals on an index card on the mirror stack real wins.

THE CORE LESSON

Confidence is generated through controllables, competence, body language, and small written goals — and over time it becomes part of who you are.

TAKEAWAYS

First. Generate confidence deliberately — give yourself permission to feel willing, worthy, and capable.

Second. Build competence; the more skill you trust, the more confident you feel.

Third. Use confident body language to create the feeling, not just to follow it.

Fourth. Set small, written, achievable goals — for thirty days, show up as the best of who you are.

MOVEMENT III

UNDER THE LIGHTS

The science and the stage

Reaction Time

The science of reacting fast

“The longer you stay fixated on the release point, the faster you will react once the shot is taken.”

KEY MOMENTS

- Drawing on Robert Kosinski’s review of the research, Buck translates the science: by Hick’s Law, fewer stimuli mean faster reactions — so narrow your focus to the release and contact point alone.
- Reaction time is fastest at an **intermediate** level of arousal; too low against a weak opponent, or too high from nerves, both slow you down. Music is a tool to tune it up or down.
- Sleep deprivation slows reaction time most of all, while the benefits of practice last about three weeks — put the stick down for the off-season and you’ll come back slower.
- Fitness, embracing pressure, and even a single cup of coffee’s worth of caffeine all sharpen reaction — while crowd noise and prior frustration dull it.

THE CORE LESSON

Reaction time is trainable: lower it by narrowing focus to the release, lengthening your fixation, tuning your arousal, sleeping, staying fit, and embracing pressure.

TAKEAWAYS

First. Cut the number of stimuli — focus only on the release and contact point.

Second. Lock onto the ball early (the dodge is your warning) and stay fixated longer to react faster.

Third. Find your intermediate arousal level, and protect it with sleep, fitness, and activity.

Fourth. Embrace pressure and minimize distraction — both directly speed your reaction.

Rods and Cones

Optimize where you look

“If you can consistently get the release point in that six percent of your vision, you will make more saves.”

KEY MOMENTS

- The X attackman wraps the crease and dunks it — “You never saw the ball, and you probably guessed.”
- The **cones** sit in the center six percent of your vision: they give the fastest reaction and the clearest, most detailed image — but they need light to work.

- The **rods** — about ninety-four percent of your receptors — cover the periphery, but their picture is blurry, colorless, and slower to process.
- Stare at a single “X” and only the center is crystal clear — the same precision you want aimed at the ball from release all the way to contact.

THE CORE LESSON

Put the ball and release point in the center six percent of your vision — the cones — to react fastest, and use your peripheral rods only to read cutters and open players.

TAKEAWAYS

First. The cones see only about six percent of your field but react fastest — aim them at the release.

Second. When you know a shot is coming, fix the ball in that center six percent all the way to contact.

Third. Use peripheral vision to track cutters and open players, not the shot itself.

Fourth. Train it in warm-up — it’s why your best games felt like slow motion.

15

Getting Off the Bench

Control, influence, and the coach

“You cannot control your playing time, but you can influence it.”

KEY MOMENTS

- Buck sorts everything into three buckets: what you **control** (thoughts, behaviors, preparation, reactions), what you **influence** (the coach, teammates, scouts), and what you **can’t control** (the lineup, refs, weather).
- Countless athletes ask the coach what to work on, get a clear answer, and then do nothing — talking to the coach isn’t action.
- Spend fifteen focused minutes a day for two weeks on exactly what the coach named, and he’ll notice — and you’ll have gotten better, too.
- The decision to play you isn’t yours; the coach is the gatekeeper — so your job is to influence that decision through visible, consistent work.

THE CORE LESSON

You can’t control your playing time, but you can influence your coach by relentlessly controlling your preparation and acting on the feedback you’re given.

TAKEAWAYS

First. Separate control, influence, and can’t-control — pour your energy only into the controllables.

Second. Ask the coach exactly what earns playing time, then actually go work on it.

Third. Put in fifteen focused minutes a day for two weeks on that gap — the coach will notice.

Fourth. Remember that talking isn’t action; influence comes from visible, consistent work.

Tryouts and Showcases

Play to win, not to perform

“The elite athletes always try to win. They very rarely try to perform — they just play.”

KEY MOMENTS

- A showcase in front of fifty college coaches tempts you to “perform” as an individual — and trying to perform rarely works out in sports.
- Coaches watch how you react to a goal: do you slam your stick and yell at the defense, or throw it to the ref and talk solutions?
- Two goalies ignored Buck’s request to back up the cage — twice. With dozens of talented goalies there that day, those two didn’t make the team.
- His rule for any tryout: **make an impact**. Be loud, be aggressive, clear with precision, go hard in lines, and help the coaches — don’t be wallpaper.

THE CORE LESSON

At tryouts and showcases, play to win and make an impact — never play to perform — because coaches are evaluating everything, especially how you handle a goal.

TAKEAWAYS

First. Play to win, not to perform — keep your focus on the field, not the sideline.

Second. Treat it like a game for your own team so energy flows into stops, clears, and communication.

Third. Make an impact — be loud, aggressive, precise, and helpful; don’t be wallpaper.

Fourth. Know that your reaction to a goal is being scored, so throw it to the ref and talk solutions.

Putting It All Together

The whole game, on a timeline

“Think like an All-American first, then become one — not the other way around.”

KEY MOMENTS

- **Off-season** (three to six months out): build talent and confidence, and keep taking shots so your reaction time doesn’t slip past the three-week mark.
- **Pre-season** (two weeks before tryouts): high-intensity reps, experiment with and own your warm-up, hone your vision, and show up ready to fight for the spot.
- **Tryouts and practice**: enter in a gladiator mindset, play to win, be loud, and bring game-day intensity every single day — because practice makes permanent.

- **Game day:** sleep well, jog off nervous energy, arrive early, tune your arousal with music, put on your equipment like a gladiator, walk on with shoulders back, breathe in dominance and blow out anxiety — you've earned this.

THE CORE LESSON

The mental game is built on a timeline — talent and confidence in the off-season, intensity and routine in the pre-season, win-mode at tryouts, intention in practice, and a full mental routine on game day.

TAKEAWAYS

First. Lay the groundwork months out — confidence and reaction time both take time to build.

Second. Own your warm-up and your vision in the pre-season, and arrive ready to fight for the job.

Third. In practice, bring game-day intensity — practice makes permanent.

Fourth. On game day, run the full routine: sleep, trigger, body language, breathe in dominance, Bring It.



PART II

THE ACTION GUIDE

Train & middot; Compete & middot; Dominate



THE ACTION GUIDE

Buck's own timeline, turned into a plan you can run

The book closes with a chronological roadmap — off-season, pre-season, tryouts, practice, game day. These three phases gather every principle into that arc. **Train** when no one is watching, **Compete** every time you step in the cage, and **Dominate** when the lights come on.

PHASE ONE

TRAIN

Off-season & pre-season — build the talent and the mind

Build talent every day.

Pick one weakness — foot speed, a new arc, off-hand passing — and drill it until it's second nature. Talent only moves incrementally, so the work has to be daily, in the cage, on the track, and in the weight room.

Keep a stick in your hand year-round.

Reaction time decays after about three weeks without reps, so play wallball and take shots even in the off-season. The talent you built in-season will quietly leak away if you don't.

Generate confidence before the season.

Don't wait for the season to feel ready. Set small, written, achievable goals on an index card on your mirror, hit them, then set new ones — and for thirty days, show up as the best of who you are.

Design a warm-up with a purpose.

Decide what each warm-up will build — stick plane, hands away from the body, square angles, finding the release — so your fifteen minutes a day actually grow your talent instead of just getting you sweaty.

Get in shape.

Fitness lowers reaction time, and the goalie finishing last in sprints is leaving saves on the field. Raise your heart rate before every session and keep moving when the ball is at the other end.

Train your eyes.

In warm-up, work at putting the release point in the center six percent of your vision — the cones — so that precise tracking is automatic by the time the season starts.

Go in ready to fight for the spot.

Don't assume who's starting. Show up to tryouts prepared to win the job from day one — maybe you start, maybe last year's starter gets hurt; either way, your time is now.

PHASE TWO

COMPETE

Practice & in-game — the disciplines that stop the ball

Bring It on every shot.

Say “Bring It! I own you!” before the ball is even in the air, and be as loud as you can to spike your intensity. You want them to shoot; that ball is yours.

Play one shot at a time.

Run Release, Replan, Refocus after every goal: ten seconds to be upset, adjust your plan, then return your eyes to the next shot. The next shot is always more important than the last.

Find the release and contact point.

The release is three to four feet from the shooter’s shoulder. Keep your chin up and eyes wide, and finish every save moving forward so the contact point stays in front of you.

Take responsibility for every goal.

Stop blaming the slide that didn’t come. Owning the goal is the only thing that gives you the power to fix it — and your defense will respect you for it.

Control the controllables.

Your thoughts, preparation, and reactions are yours; the refs, the weather, and your playing time are not. Pour energy only into what you own — everything else is just suffering.

Treat practice like a game.

Practice makes permanent, so how you play in practice is how you’ll play in the game. Bring game-day intensity and intention to every rep, including warm-up.

Break the glass.

Give every drill a purpose. Picture the pane of glass a foot in front of your stick and ask “Did I save the glass?” after each shot, so you’re training with intention, not just stopping balls.

PHASE THREE

DOMINATE

Game day & the big stage — bring it when it counts

Run the gladiator routine.

As you put on your helmet and gloves, become a gladiator heading into the arena. It’s a trigger to reach your optimal mindset fifteen to thirty minutes before you hit the field.

Breathe in dominance.

Shoulders back, chin up, chest out. As you watch the other team warm up, breathe in dominance and blow out anxiety — a confident body creates a confident mind.

Embrace the nerves.

The Final Four feeling is a privilege, not a threat — if you didn't care, you wouldn't feel it. Slow down, take long deep breaths, and let the anxiety remind you that you're alive.

Play to win, not to perform.

At tryouts and showcases, keep your eyes on the field, not the sideline or the stands. Trying to perform rarely works; elite players just play.

Make an impact.

Be loud, aggressive, and precise. Clear with intention, help the coaches, and never be wallpaper — every action off the ball is being evaluated.

Climb out of the spiral.

If you've let a few in, flip back to Bring It — head higher, hands out front — and refocus on the next shot. The spiral runs on momentum, and you don't bank on momentum.

Remember you've earned this.

All the work started six months ago. Get your sleep, tune your arousal with music, and walk on knowing the cage is yours. This is your time.

QUICK REFERENCE

One principle per chapter — print it, pin it, live it

01. Performance equals Talent minus Interference, plus or minus Luck — keep your interference near zero.
 02. Choose fight over flight, and earn your bruises.
 03. The next shot is the only shot that will ever matter.
 04. If you can't see it, you can't stop it — find the release and contact point.
 05. Bring It! Your desire to stop the ball must beat the fear of getting hit.
 06. Mental toughness is learnable — control the controllables.
 07. Climb the pyramid, and reach for composure.
 08. Responsibility = Response Ability — own every goal.
 09. Recognize the nerves, breathe, and embrace them.
 10. Never bank on momentum — refuse the downward spiral.
 11. Every warm-up needs a purpose; practice makes permanent.
 12. Confidence is generated, not given.
 13. Fewer stimuli and longer focus — react faster.
 14. Aim the center six percent of your vision at the release.
 15. You can't control playing time, but you can influence it.
 16. Play to win, not to perform — make an impact.
 17. Build it on a timeline; on game day, you've earned it.
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“Playing with confidence, passion, and a little bit of swagger. Think like an All-American first, then become one.”